

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump said he would soon make a decision on a deal with **Iran**. In a social-media post he wrote that the Strait of Hormuz must be reopened to commercial shipping and that America would lift its blockade. Meanwhile, us Central Command warned that it would target mine-laying vessels in self defence as part of a military operation in the Strait of Hormuz.

Pete Hegseth told an audience at the **Shangri-La Dialogue**, an annual gabfest of defence ministers, that America's relations with China were "better than they've been in many years". But America's secretary of war said that China's "historic military build-up" meant that his country's allies ought to spend more on defence. Last year Mr Hegseth warned of the "threat" of China invading Taiwan; this year he [did not mention the island](#).

A flurry of **defence tie-ups** were also announced at **Shangri-La**. America, Australia and Britain (an alliance known as AUKUS) said they would together develop aquatic drones to protect subsea cables. Mr Hegseth declared that America, Japan and South Korea were "deepening" their defence co-operation. And India said that it had finalised with Vietnam a sale of its supersonic, long-range BrahMos missiles.

Colombia accused **Ecuador** of interfering in its [upcoming election](#), after Ecuador's president promised to lift tariffs on Colombian imports. The pledge was part of an agreement made with Abelardo de la Espriella, an opposition candidate. Colombia said Ecuador's decision to remove the tariffs was not a "goodwill gesture". But it also agreed to repeal reciprocal measures it had placed on its neighbour, thawing a months-long trade war.

Russia recalled its ambassador to **Armenia** in protest at its ally's attempts to establish closer ties with the European Union. Its foreign ministry accused Armenia of "undermining" the Russia-led Eurasian Economic Union. It had earlier threatened to halt or end the supply of oil, gas and diamonds to Armenia after the country declared it wanted to join the EU.

Ghana's parliament passed a bill making it illegal to say you are **LGBT+** or to have gay sex. It also criminalises being an "ally" and requires others to report violations of the law. A similar bill was passed in 2024 but Nana Akufo-Addo, the president at the time, did not sign it. Ghana's current president, John Mahama, previously indicated that he may make this one law.

Paris St Germain defeated Arsenal in a penalty shoot-out to win its second consecutive **Champions League** final. Fresh off their [Premier League win](#), Arsenal hoped to take down the French powerhouse, but missed two penalties after drawing 1-1.

Word of the week: *Hivernauts*, those who spend the winter in the extreme isolation of a polar-research station in Antarctica. Read about the impact [such an environment](#) can have.



Photograph: Reuters

Russia and Ukraine escalate aerial strikes

So far Russia has little to show for its long-awaited summer offensive. Earlier this month Mykhailo Federov, Ukraine's defence minister, claimed his country was slowing down Russia and "gradually [regaining the initiative](#)". He has attributed this to Ukraine's medium-range strike campaign, which targets air-defence systems, logistics hubs, command posts and supply routes between 20 and 300 kilometres behind the front line.

Ukraine's strikes, which have quadrupled in intensity in recent months, have resulted in record [Russian losses](#). Six months ago the country was losing 67 soldiers for every kilometre of advance; in April the number rose to 179. Yet Russia's aerial threat remains. This week Volodymyr Zelensky urged Donald Trump to send more Patriot interceptor missiles. After burning through interceptors early in the Iran war, however, the Pentagon's stocks are depleted—while Ukraine's ability to defend civilian targets grows ever more critical. Russia is now threatening to hit "decision-making centres" in Kyiv.



Photograph: Sean Gleason

The story behind a famous nude painting

It has everything you need for a good story: eccentric artists, inflated egos, glamour, nudity, drugs and debauchery. “Moss & Freud”, a film released in cinemas in Britain this week, examines the unlikely friendship between Kate Moss, a supermodel, and Lucian Freud, a figurative artist. (Freud painted Ms Moss over nine months in 2002; the work sold for £3.9m.)

Unfortunately, the film manages to be less spectacular than spectacularly dull. There is little chemistry between the lead characters, with Derek Jacobi playing Freud and Ellie Bamber as Ms Moss. Nor does the script find anything profound to say. Even the most unexpected moments—the pair take opium together, for instance, and Freud recounts the experience of being dragged along the floor by a zebra—somehow fall flat. “A moment of complete happiness never occurs in the creation of a work of art,” Freud wrote. Or in watching it, viewers of this film may conclude.



Photograph: Reuters

Weekend profile: Iván Cepeda, the Colombian leftist who wants peace and power

On August 9th 1994, a then-31-year-old Iván Cepeda was on a bus heading to university in Bogotá, Colombia's capital, when he spotted a car belonging to his father, a communist senator, riddled with bullets. Inside was his father's mutilated body; his bodyguards were crying nearby. Speaking to reporters shortly afterwards, [Mr Cepeda](#), then an academic philosopher, called for punishment for the murder, which he surmised was part of an "offensive against left-wing leaders". But he also called for peace.

Today Mr Cepeda is himself a hard-left senator and a presidential candidate, and dialogue is at the heart of his campaign. His slogan is "the power of truth", a reflection of his lifelong commitment to justice for the 9.8m victims of the country's 62-year civil war (which includes those forcibly displaced or who suffered atrocities). In 2016 the government signed a historic peace agreement with the biggest rebel group, but recent attempts at other deals, backed by Mr Cepeda, have failed. Violence is rising and peace talks are deeply divisive. Mr Cepeda is expected to win most votes in the first round of [Sunday's election](#) (though it will probably go to a run-off).

The stakes are unusually high. The election will signal whether the right-wing wave sweeping Latin America has crested. The calm

and austere Mr Cepeda—who wears Nehru-collared shirts and his father’s old Russian watch—hopes to beat the hard-right Abelardo de la Espriella, who calls himself “El Tigre” (and who claims a photo of himself in tight trousers, apparently suggesting he has a big penis, has helped win women’s votes). Mr Cepeda’s political inspiration is José Mujica, a former guerrilla who became Uruguay’s president while continuing to drive a battered Volkswagen Beetle; Mr de la Espriella’s are Donald Trump and Nayib Bukele, the iron-fisted president of El Salvador.

After his father’s murder Mr Cepeda uncovered abuses by state forces, as well as pushed peace negotiations. (He eventually proved the state assassinated his father with right-wing militias and received a formal apology in 2011.) His determination to root out paramilitarism from Congress dragged him into a 13-year legal battle with Álvaro Uribe, a powerful former president who took on the rebels to restore some order, whom Mr Cepeda had accused of forming a right-wing death squad in the 1990s. (The case is still not fully resolved.)

Now Mr Cepeda faces his greatest test. Gustavo Petro, Colombia’s first left-wing president, who is constitutionally limited to one four-year term, has passed him the torch. Mr Cepeda wants to redistribute land using voluntary state purchases and seizures from drug gangs, and to increase taxes to pay for higher welfare spending. Rivals claim he is a Marxist who will wipe out Colombia’s recent economic progress and a threat to democracy.

Mr Cepeda insists he does not want a state-run economy, just a more equal one. He hopes to redistribute 1m hectares of land, to be bought from cattle ranchers, to smallholders. But his main goal is a national accord on peace, education and poverty. If he wins, cutting through Colombia’s [political polarisation](#) will test even Mr Cepeda’s belief in dialogue.

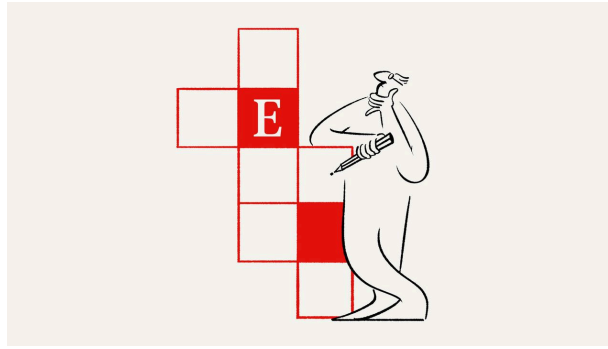


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Some fool gives back to house a homeless eskimo (5)

2 across - Bum around November goes down in history (5)

3 across - Unacceptable, whichever way you look at it (3,2)

1 down - Supply in loaf tin gets more expensive (9)

Straight clues

1 across - An icy dwelling (5)

2 across - A historical record (5)

3 across - Unthinkable; off or postponed (3,2)

1 down - Growth, not always welcome (5)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Maria Manuela DaCosta, Eau Claire, Wisconsin

Ron Toogood, Moncton, Canada

Paul de Wouters, Basel, Switzerland

They all gave the correct answers of: John Warner, Frank Lloyd Wright, the blues, Karl Marx and Ben Grimm. The theme is famous brothers: Warner brothers, Weight brothers, The Blues Brothers, Marx Brothers and the Brothers Grimm.

The questions were:

Monday: Which Republican Senator from Virginia was married to Elizabeth Taylor?

Tuesday: Which architect designed the Guggenheim museum in New York?

Wednesday: Robert Johnson and Muddy Waters were pioneers in which music genre?

Thursday: Which philosopher and economist was born in Trier in 1818 and died in London in 1883?

Friday: What is the civilian name of the superhero “The Thing” in the Fantastic Four stories?

*Blessed is he who expects nothing,
for he shall never be
disappointed.*

Alexander Pope